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The Boolean Cheat Sheet

Everything you need to write a search string that returns real people — on four pages.

Six operators do ninety per cent of the work

Learn these and you can write most of the searches you will ever need. Everything else is practice.

Operator	What it does	Example
AND	Both concepts must be present. Narrows the search.	Java AND "Spring Boot"
OR	Any one of the alternatives. Broadens. Always bracket it.	("Java Developer" OR "Backend Engineer")
NOT	Excludes a concept. Use it last, and use it sparingly.	Developer NOT (intern OR trainee)
" "	Exact phrase. Also stops auto-stemming on Dice.	"Site Reliability Engineer"
()	Groups alternatives so the logic reads correctly.	(AWS OR Azure OR GCP)
-	Google's exclusion operator. Replaces NOT in X-ray strings.	-jobs -hiring -"we are looking"

Four rules that break searches silently

Your search still runs. It just returns the wrong thing, and nothing warns you.

Operators must be **CAPITALS**.

On LinkedIn, Naukri and most platforms a lower-case and is treated as an ordinary word.

Brackets decide the meaning.

Java AND Python OR Scala is ambiguous. Java AND (Python OR Scala) is not. When in doubt, add brackets — they never hurt.

Wildcards mostly do not work.

LinkedIn does not support asterisks or braces. Naukri Resdex supports no wildcards, no regex and no proximity operators. Write the variations out with OR instead.

Plus and minus are not LinkedIn operators.

Use AND and NOT there. On Google X-ray it is the reverse — the minus sign is the only exclusion that works.

The exclusion trap

NOT ruins more searches than any other operator. Every term you exclude removes people silently — you never see who you lost. Exclude "junior" and you lose the senior engineer who mentors juniors. Add exclusions last, one at a time, and only for a pattern you have actually seen repeating in your results.

METHOD

How to build a string in six steps

Use this every time. It works on LinkedIn, Naukri, Dice, your ATS and Google.

01 Start with the title, not the skill

Write every name the market uses for this job and OR them together. A Java backend role is also advertised as Software Engineer, Application Developer and Backend Engineer. Miss the synonyms and you lose half the market before you start.

02 Add the one skill the job cannot exist without

Not four skills. One. The language, the platform or the product. Everything else is a filter you add later.

03 Add a second must-have only if the pool is still too broad

Run the search first. Read the first twenty profiles. Add the second concept only if the noise is real, not because the JD listed it.

04 Group every alternative in brackets

(Kubernetes OR K8s). (SDET OR "QA Automation"). Abbreviations and full forms are different words to a search engine — they are only the same thing to you.

05 Exclude last, and only what you have seen

Open twenty results, find the recurring irrelevance, then exclude that. Excluding on a guess removes good people and you never find out.

06 Save it, log what it returned, write a broader twin

The narrow search fills today's role. The broad one tells you what the market actually holds.

What a finished string looks like

The JD says: Java, Spring Boot, microservices, AWS, 5 years, Pune. Here is that requirement turned into a search.

TITLES → CORE SKILL → ARCHITECTURE → PLATFORM → LOCATION

("Java Developer" OR "Java Engineer" OR "Backend Engineer" OR "Software Engineer") AND ("Spring Boot" OR Spring) AND (microservices OR REST OR API) AND (AWS OR "Amazon Web Services") AND (Pune OR Hinjewadi)

Notice what is missing: the five years. Experience is a filter field, not a keyword — and years are the weakest evidence of seniority you can use.

THE LIBRARY

Ten strings you can run today

Each one is a starting point, not a final answer. Run it, read twenty results, then change one thing.

Java backend

```
("Java Developer" OR "Java Engineer" OR "Backend Engineer") AND ("Spring Boot" OR Spring) AND (microservices OR REST OR API)
```

Frontend / React

```
("Frontend Developer" OR "React Developer" OR "UI Developer") AND (React OR ReactJS) AND (JavaScript OR TypeScript)
```

Full stack

```
("Full Stack Developer" OR "Fullstack Engineer") AND (React OR Angular) AND (Java OR "Node.js" OR Python) AND (SQL OR MongoDB)
```

DevOps / SRE

```
("DevOps Engineer" OR SRE OR "Platform Engineer") AND (Kubernetes OR K8s) AND (AWS OR Azure OR GCP) AND (Terraform OR Ansible)
```

Cloud engineer

```
("Cloud Engineer" OR "AWS Engineer" OR "Cloud Architect") AND (AWS OR "Amazon Web Services") AND (EC2 OR S3 OR Lambda OR EKS)
```

Data engineer

```
("Data Engineer" OR "Big Data Engineer" OR "ETL Developer") AND (Python OR Scala) AND (Spark OR Databricks) AND (ETL OR ELT OR pipeline)
```

Analytics / BI

```
("Data Analyst" OR "BI Developer" OR "Business Intelligence") AND (SQL) AND ("Power BI" OR Tableau OR Looker) AND (dashboard OR DAX)
```

QA automation / SDET

```
("Automation Tester" OR "QA Automation" OR SDET) AND (Selenium OR Cypress OR Playwright) AND (Java OR Python OR JavaScript)
```

SOC analyst

```
("SOC Analyst" OR "Security Analyst" OR "Cybersecurity Analyst") AND (SIEM OR Splunk OR Sentinel) AND (incident OR detection OR triage)
```

Salesforce

```
("Salesforce Developer" OR "SFDC Developer" OR "Salesforce Consultant") AND (Apex OR Lightning OR LWC) AND (integration OR API)
```

City names in India have official and colloquial forms, and candidates use both. Bolt the right group onto any string above:
(Bengaluru OR Bangalore) · (Gurugram OR Gurgaon OR Noida OR "Delhi NCR") · (Mumbai OR Bombay OR Thane) ·
(Hyderabad OR Secunderabad) · (Pune OR Hinjewadi).

DIAGNOSTICS

When the search is not working

Every recruiter hits these two walls daily. The fix is almost never a longer string — it is a smarter one. Work down the list in order.

Too many results

- Move the title group into the title field instead of the keyword field.
- Add one more must-have — one, and only after reading twenty results.
- Tighten a loose OR group. (Cloud) is not a skill; (AWS OR Azure OR GCP) is.
- Quote multi-word phrases so “project manager” stops matching a project and a manager.
- Add the location group, using local spellings and abbreviations.
- Exclude the pattern you can actually see repeating in the results.

Too few results

- Remove the newest technology first — older profiles will not list it.
- Add title synonyms: Software Engineer as well as Developer.
- Add abbreviations: (K8s OR Kubernetes), (SFDC OR Salesforce).
- Delete your exclusions and re-run. NOT is the usual culprit.
- Drop from three must-haves to two and screen the difference manually.
- Widen the location group, or check a nearby metro for relocators.

Six mistakes that cost the most time

- 01 Pasting the whole job description into the search box.
- 02 Using one exact job title and assuming the market uses it too.
- 03 Forgetting brackets around an OR group, so the logic silently changes.
- 04 Judging a search by how many results it returned instead of how relevant the first twenty are.
- 05 Assuming a string that worked on LinkedIn behaves the same on Naukri or Dice.
- 06 Never saving the string, so tomorrow you start again from nothing.

The string is not the job

A search builds a list. A screening call builds a shortlist. The recruiters who get hired are the ones who can read a technical requirement, judge whether the evidence in a resume is real, and explain the decision afterwards.

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hello@rtechx.com

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Free to share — pass it to anyone learning to source. Platform behaviour changes without notice, so always test a new string against a candidate you already know is in the database before you trust it.